

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 16

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A young teacher describes her first morning standing in front of her own class.

1

I had rehearsed the opening sentence in my bathroom mirror for three weeks. **Good morning, class. My name is Miss Tan, and I will be your form teacher this year.** I had practised it cheerful, practised it stern, practised it somewhere in between. By the Sunday night before school began, I could deliver it without thinking — which, as it turned out, was precisely the problem. A sentence that has been said two hundred times to a mirror has, by then, lost something that a sentence said once to thirty real children still possesses.

2

The bell rang at seven thirty. I walked down the corridor with what I hoped looked like the brisk confidence of a teacher, although my file was clamped against my chest like a shield, and my new shoes — bought specially, and a half-size too small — were already biting at my heels. Outside the classroom door I paused. Through the small glass panel I could see them: thirty heads, some bent over phones, some turned to a neighbour, one already laughing at a joke I would never hear. I took a breath that did not quite fill my lungs, fixed my smile, and pushed the door open.

3

The room fell into the kind of half-silence that is not really silence at all. Thirty pairs of eyes swung towards me with the practised, evaluating gaze of children who have, over many years, become connoisseurs of new teachers. I crossed to the front. I set my file on the desk. I turned. I opened my mouth to begin — and discovered, in the same instant, two things. First, that my rehearsed sentence had vanished entirely. Second, that I had forgotten to bring a marker for the whiteboard.

4

For perhaps five seconds I simply stood there. The smile, so carefully fixed, began to twitch at the corners. I could feel the colour climbing my neck the way ink climbs blotting paper. Somewhere in the second

row, a boy whispered something to his neighbour, and the neighbour smothered a laugh. I thought, with a clarity I have never quite forgotten, **I cannot do this. They will know. They already know.** And then, from the very front row, a small voice spoke up.

5

“Teacher,” said a girl with two neat plaits, “do you want me to lend you a pen? The whiteboard kind. I have a spare.” She was already half out of her seat, holding it out, with the unselfconscious kindness of a child who has not yet learned that adults are supposed to manage on their own. I took it. My fingers were not quite steady. “Thank you,” I said — and to my own astonishment, my voice came out level, almost ordinary. “That is very thoughtful of you. What is your name?”

6

“Sarah, teacher.”

“Thank you, Sarah.”

I turned to the board and wrote, in handwriting that surprised me by being legible, **Miss Tan — Form 1E**. When I turned back, something in the room had shifted. The boy in the second row was no longer whispering. Sarah was sitting very straight, as though she had been entrusted with something important. I looked at thirty faces, and they looked back, and I understood — slowly, and with a relief that almost made my eyes water — that they were not, after all, my enemies. They were children. They had been waiting, all this time, for someone to begin.

7

I do not remember what I said next. I remember that the rehearsed sentence stayed lost, and that what came out in its place was a clumsier, truer thing about being new, and being nervous, and being glad to meet them. I remember that someone asked whether I liked dogs, and that I said yes, and that this seemed, for some reason, to settle a question I had not known was being asked. By the time the bell rang for the next period, I had learned eleven names. I had not, yet, taught them anything. But I had, perhaps, become — just a little — their teacher.

8

That was twelve years ago. The new shoes were thrown out within a fortnight. The file is in a box somewhere in my parents’ flat. Sarah is, I am told, reading law at a university overseas. I keep the marker, capped and dried out, in the top drawer of my desk, where I see it every morning when I sit down. It reminds me that the children one fears, on a first morning, are almost always kinder than one deserves — and that a teacher, in the end, is not a person who knows everything, but a person who is willing to be helped.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says her rehearsed sentence had, by Sunday night, “lost something that a sentence said once to thirty real children still possesses.” Explain, in your own words, what she means. [2]

From Paragraph 2

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that show the narrator was anxious despite trying to appear confident. [2]

From Paragraph 3

3. The narrator describes her pupils as having “the practised, evaluating gaze of children who have, over many years, become connoisseurs of new teachers.” Explain what this phrase suggests about the children. [2]

4. In Paragraph 3, the narrator uses three short sentences: “I crossed to the front. I set my file on the desk. I turned.” What is the **effect** of writing in this way? [2]

From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator says she “could feel the colour climbing [her] neck the way ink climbs blotting paper.” Explain how this comparison helps the reader to picture her embarrassment. [2]

From Paragraph 5

6. The narrator describes Sarah’s kindness as “the unselfconscious kindness of a child who has not yet learned that adults are supposed to manage on their own.”

- (a) What does the word **unselfconscious** tell us about Sarah’s behaviour? [1]
(b) What does the second half of the phrase suggest about adults, in the narrator’s view? [1]

From Paragraph 6

7. The narrator writes that, after Sarah’s offer, “something in the room had shifted.” Give **two** details from Paragraph 6 that show this change. [2]

8. The narrator says she felt “a relief that almost made my eyes water.” What does this suggest about how worried she had been before this moment? [1]

From Paragraph 7

9. The narrator says that what came out in place of her rehearsed sentence was “a clumsier, truer thing.” Why does she describe what she actually said as both **clumsier** and **truer**? [2]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator keeps the marker, “capped and dried out”, in her desk drawer. What does this object seem to **symbolise** for her? [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the vanishing dialects of Asia and what can be done to preserve them.

1

A linguist who has spent thirty years in the field will tell you, often without prompting, that languages are not so much spoken as inherited. They are passed down at kitchen tables, in market lanes, in the small jokes that grandparents make to grandchildren. When that chain of inheritance is broken — when a child no longer needs, or wishes, to reply in the tongue her grandmother addresses her in — the language begins, very quietly, to die. Across Asia, this kind of quiet dying is happening on a startling scale. UNESCO estimates that of the roughly two thousand four hundred languages and dialects spoken on the continent, more than half may fall silent before the end of this century.

2

The numbers, on their own, are easy to dismiss. A dialect is, after all, only one way of saying things that can be said in another. Why mourn the loss of, say, Kristang, the creole of Portuguese-descended Eurasians in Malacca, when the speakers themselves are perfectly fluent in English and Malay? The answer, linguists insist, is that a language is never **only** a way of saying things. It is a way of **seeing** things. The Mon dialect of southern Myanmar contains a verb tense for actions completed before the speaker was born — a feature that quietly reshapes how its speakers think about memory and inheritance. When the last fluent speaker of Mon dies, that tense, and the way of thinking that depends on it, dies too.

3

The pressures driving this loss are familiar but powerful. Formal schooling, almost everywhere in the region, is conducted in a single national or international language. Examinations are written in it; jobs are advertised in it; films and pop music are produced in it. A parent who chooses to bring up a child in a small dialect must do so in the face of every signal that society sends about which tongue “matters”. The result, repeated in tens of thousands of homes, is a slow standardisation: children grow up understanding their grandparents’ dialect but unable, when their own turn comes, to speak it back to their children.

4

Against this tide, a quiet counter-movement has emerged. In Singapore, a handful of young Kristang enthusiasts have spent the last decade running free weekly classes, producing children’s storybooks, and writing pop songs in a dialect that, in the 1990s, was confidently declared moribund. In the Philippines, the **Sinugbuanong Binisaya** revival has placed dialect-language signage in schools and public hospitals. In the Indian state of Sikkim, indigenous communities have negotiated with the state government to have local tongues taught alongside Hindi and English from the first year of primary school. These projects rarely produce, by themselves, a fluent new generation. What they produce, more modestly, is a generation that knows its dialect **exists** — and that is, surprisingly often, the first step towards keeping it alive.

5

Technology has played a curious, double-edged role. On one side, it has hastened decline: social-media feeds, dominated by a few high-prestige languages, push smaller tongues further to the margin of a young person’s day. On the other side, the very same platforms have given dialect communities tools their grandparents could not have dreamed of. Free online dictionaries, crowdsourced by amateurs and refined by linguists, now exist for languages that, twenty years ago, had no written form at all. A teenager in Sabah can record her great-uncle reciting a folk story on her phone, upload it to a public archive, and add subtitles in three languages, all before dinner. What was once the painstaking work of a visiting researcher has become, in some places, a family weekend project.

6

None of this should be mistaken for victory. For every Kristang revival, there are a dozen smaller dialects whose last speakers are in their eighties and whose grandchildren have, politely but firmly, switched to the national language. The economic logic that punishes small tongues has not changed. A child who speaks fluent Mandarin or English will, in most Asian economies, find more doors open to her than a child who speaks fluent Iban or Cham. To pretend otherwise is to ask families to bear, alone, a cost that ought to be shared by the wider society that benefits from the diversity they preserve.

7

What, then, can an ordinary person do? More, perhaps, than is usually supposed. Speak the dialect, however imperfectly, to the children in your household. Buy the children's book even if you must ask a relative to translate it. Subtitle the video. Ask the grandparent, before it is too late, to record the recipe in her own words and her own tongue. A language does not die because it is killed by an enemy. It dies because, one ordinary day at a time, the people who could have spoken it chose, understandably and quietly, to speak something else. The reverse is also true — and that, in the end, is where hope lives.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that languages are “passed down at kitchen tables, in market lanes, in the small jokes that grandparents make to grandchildren.” Explain, in your own words, what this suggests about how languages are kept alive. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. The writer poses the question: “Why mourn the loss of... Kristang... when the speakers themselves are perfectly fluent in English and Malay?” Why does the writer ask this question at this point in the text? [2]

14. According to Paragraph 2, why is the loss of the Mon verb tense more serious than it might first appear? Answer in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Give **two** ways in which, according to Paragraph 3, formal schooling and society push parents away from raising children in a small dialect. [2]

From Paragraph 4

16. The writer puts the word “matters” in inverted commas in Paragraph 3. What is the writer suggesting by doing this? [1]

17. The writer says revival projects “rarely produce, by themselves, a fluent new generation.” What, according to Paragraph 4, do they more modestly achieve? Answer in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. Explain, in your own words, the **two opposite** effects that technology has had on dying dialects, according to Paragraph 5. [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. The writer says, “None of this should be mistaken for victory.” What is the writer’s **tone** in this sentence, and why does he adopt it here? [2]

20. According to Paragraph 6, why is it unfair to expect individual families, on their own, to keep small dialects alive? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the article by saying, “A language does not die because it is killed by an enemy. It dies because, one ordinary day at a time, the people who could have spoken it chose, understandably and quietly, to speak something else.” Explain what is **effective** about this contrast. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the pressures that are causing Asian dialects to disappear**, and **what is being done to revive them**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 5** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Asian dialects are disappearing because ...

— END OF PAPER —